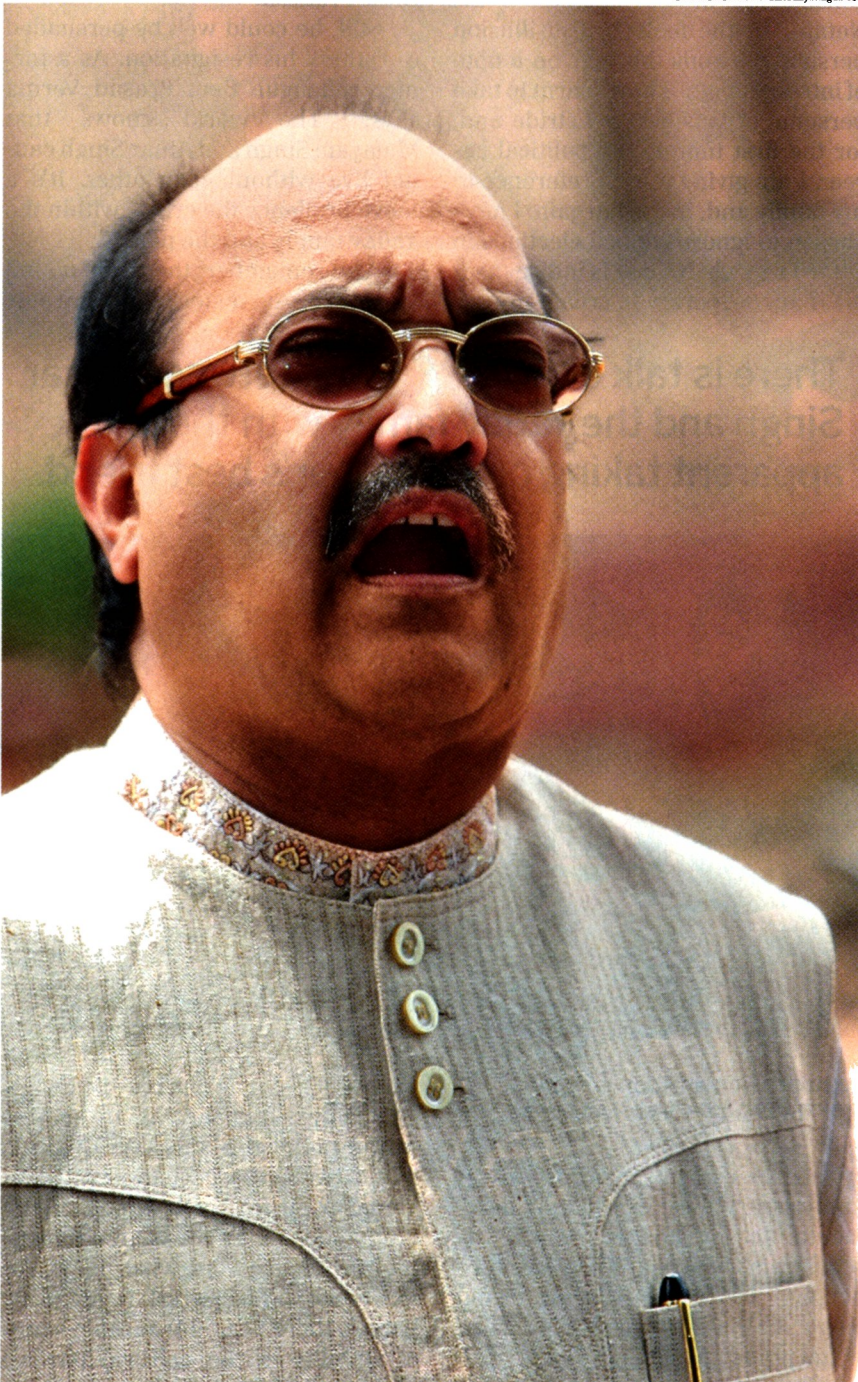


Strategic RETREAT

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Sidelined by the Mulayam clan, the hurt Samajwadi leader and master networker renounces power for a better bargain

| By Priya Sahgal |

He marvelled at the world's tallest building and apparently had an epiphany. On January 4, Amar Singh invited Sanjay Dutt to view the inauguration of the 2,716.5-ft Burj Khalifa in Dubai from his flat on the 54th floor of the Dubai Mall. A few days earlier Amitabh Bachchan and Anil Ambani had dropped in for a visit. It was business as usual in the wide, charmed world of Amar Singh, one of India's most resourceful politicians and a maestro of backrooms. Two days later, he announced his resignation from all the posts he was holding in the Samajwadi Party (SP). The sudden act of renunciation by someone who draws his oxygen from political combustion has once more put him where he belongs: the front pages and prime time TV screens.

Why now? Maybe the flesh can no longer keep pace with the spirit, for he is still recovering from a kidney transplant. Or maybe the irrepressible Thakur has been let down by his own party. For some time now, trouble had been brewing between him and some of his colleagues in the party. Singh has been coping with the disgruntled and the jealous within the party ever since he became the closest confidant of Mulayam Singh Yadav, and the party's face and soundbite supplier in Delhi. The last blow seems to have been the SP's loss in the Firozabad by-election in November. Mulayam had fielded his daughter-in-law Dimple from the party stronghold. Amar Singh blamed Mulayam and his family for

Amar Singh is at his manoeuvring best when **POWER IS A GAME** for the foxiest to win and he is the axis of the political whirl.